efforts to manufacture Sputnik, the Russian vaccine, have so far borne no fruit. The result is that between them, SII and BBIL have supplied over 1.4 billion doses to the Indian government since January 2021, with SII accounting for around 85 per cent of it. As of December 27, over 830 million people had received their first dose and 580 million had been given double doses. It was a herculean effort and credit goes to the outstanding work done by both central and state governments and their agencies to ensure that inoculation centres were set up with quality storage and safety practices across the country—all done with speed and battling great odds.

The central government has paid the two companies a whopping Rs 23,000 crore altogether. This has given them the incentive to not only augment their existing supply but also work on newer vaccines. BBIL is on the verge of getting clearance for its nasal vaccine. Ella calls it the 'kiss vaccine' because it protects the nasal passage, mouth and the upper respiratory tract—the key areas vulnerable to the virus. Bhushan believes that if it is cleared, it will be a game changer because the ease of administering it could help overcome vaccine hesitancy. Meanwhile, SII has got clearance for Covovax, a protein sub-unit vaccine that it has manufactured in collaboration with Novavax, the US biotech company, and the Coalition for Epidemic Preparedness and Innovation (CEPI).

Bhushan sees the success of Adar Poonawalla (who took a huge risk by stockpiling vaccines even before they were cleared) and Krishna Ella in using the oldest and safest platform to make a vaccine indigenously as signs of India's vaccine capability truly coming of age. India was already the vaccine capital of the world before Covid struck, supplying over 60 per cent of the world's needs. As Bhushan says, "Now that we can move from the R&D stage to approval and supply all in one year for vaccines—when earlier it could take years to do so—it will be a huge fillip for the future." For him, the lessons are that "we must be proactive and encourage R&D, that we must trust our manufacturers to deliver and support them financially and in other ways. This would result in us having strong multinational companies headquartered in India, and not in Europe or the US".



"Now that we can move from R&D stage to approval and supply all in one year for vaccines, it will be a huge fillip for the future"

RAJESH BHUSHAN
Union health secretary



"This was an opportunity to show the world India's ability to come up with cutting edge products developed with exclusive domestic expertise"

DR BALRAM BHARGAVA
Director-general, ICMR

Yet, even as we celebrate the success of the country's adult vaccination programme, as 2022 dawned, the threat of Covid-19 remained as high not just in India but across the world. The virus has shown that it was wilier than humans by mutating to an even more virulent variant called Omicron that has already forced countries to impose lockdowns and India to re-introduce night curfews in many cities. Yet, if the vaccines haven't been able to defeat the virus, despite its many avatars, Covid-19 too has been corralled to an extent. Both Covaxin and Covishield are shown to provide good immunity from the variant, though it may decline as months go by, necessitating a booster dose for recipients.

The resurgence of the virus doesn't detract from the enormous good that has resulted from the efforts of Ella and Poonawalla. There were other worthy newsmakers in 2021 whom we have profiled in the following pages, including Mamata Banerjee, for winning a third term as chief minister of West Bengal by thrashing the BJP; Prime Minister Narendra Modi, for making a major privatisation push to overcome the hesitancy of the past; a clutch of business start-ups gaining unicorn status despite the economic downturn; Neeraj Chopra, for winning India's first Olympic gold in athletics and our hearts with his sporting feat; and Akshay Kumar and Bhuvan Bam for hogging the entertainment limelight with their masterly performances.

But none of them could overshadow the singular achievement of Krishna Ella and Adar Poonawalla for saving thousands of lives and making us feel safer with their vaccines against the worst catastrophe that has befallen humankind in recent years. For this reason, INDIA TODAY has declared them Newsmakers of the Year 2021. ■